from the US embassy in Islamabad said that the Taliban's origins and future remain an enigma, with even the most well-informed speculation confronted with paradoxes. The Americans were certainly not able to judge between what was considered the 'good' Taliban and the 'bad' Taliban. However, a US Department of State memorandum in December 1994 disclosed that the Taliban was directly supported by the ISI.

During his meeting with US Acting Secretary of State Strobe Talbott on 9 February 1996, Pakistani Foreign Minister Asif Ali denied any Pakistani involvement in the growth of the Taliban. A US Department of State cable said:

Ali categorically denied that Pakistan provided military assistance to the Taliban and urged the US to work with Pakistan on the basic principles of a peace plan, which would become the United Nations plan.

Pakistan's ISI chief Naseem Rana, who also attended the meeting, assured Talbott that Pakistan gave 'not one bullet' to the Taliban movement. Several documents released by the US government under the Freedom of Information Act, heavily sanitised though they may be, revealed that the US government was eager to engage with the Mullah Omar-led Taliban

government despite knowing its terror capability and its attempts to protect and sponsor Al-Qaeda elements including Osama bin Laden.

A US Department of State cable dated 26 September 1996 said:

In our initial contacts with the new authorities in Kabul, we will seek information about the new government and its intentions, and reiterate our key concerns—the importance of a